

The Colonial Legacy and State Formation in Pakistan

Introduction

- Pakistan emerged in 1947 not as a blank slate but as a successor state of British India.
- The new country inherited laws, bureaucracy, army, and administrative culture.
- These colonial structures deeply influenced how the Pakistani state developed.
- Understanding this legacy helps explain present political problems.

What is Colonial Legacy?

- Colonial legacy means the systems and practices left behind by colonial rulers.
- These include bureaucracy, courts, police, army, taxation, and governance style.
- They were created to control people rather than empower them.
- After independence, Pakistan continued using most of these institutions.

What is State Formation?

- State formation refers to building effective institutions that govern society.
- It includes creating law and order, collecting taxes, delivering services, and gaining public loyalty.
- For Pakistan, state formation was difficult because institutions were weak and resources scarce.
- Thus colonial inheritance strongly shaped the process.

British Objectives in India

- The British ruled India mainly to protect imperial interests and extract resources.
- Their focus was stability, revenue collection, and prevention of rebellion.
- They did not prioritize democracy or mass participation.
- Therefore, institutions were authoritarian and centralized.

Nature of the Colonial State

- The colonial state concentrated power in a few officials such as governors and commissioners.
- Ordinary people had little voice in decision making.
- Strict laws and police ensured obedience.
- This culture of command and control continued after independence.

Administrative Structure Inherited by Pakistan

- Pakistan inherited the Indian Civil Service, district administration, police, and revenue system.
- Deputy Commissioners exercised wide powers over law and order and development.
- The system was hierarchical and centralized.
- It provided efficiency but little democratic accountability.

Civil Service Characteristics

- Civil servants were highly educated and recruited through competitive exams.
- They considered themselves guardians of the state rather than servants of the people.
- They valued order, discipline, and control.
- This mindset shaped governance in early Pakistan.

Impact on Pakistan's Bureaucracy

- Because politicians were inexperienced, bureaucrats took control of policy making.
- They drafted laws, planned development, and managed administration.
- This created bureaucratic dominance over elected representatives.
- Democratic growth was therefore restricted.

Judicial and Legal Legacy

- Pakistan retained British common law and legal codes such as the Penal Code.
- Courts were organized and systematic, which provided continuity.
- However, laws were often rigid and formalistic.
- Justice focused more on maintaining order than social change.

Police System

- The police were originally designed to suppress dissent and maintain colonial authority.
- Their structure emphasized force rather than public service.
- After independence, this coercive style largely continued.

Military Inheritance

- The British Indian Army was professional, disciplined, and well trained.
- It had strong internal unity and clear command structure.
- At independence, it became Pakistan's most organized institution.
- This later enabled the military to dominate politics.

Military's Growing Political Role

- Frequent political instability made the military appear more capable than civilians.
- Security threats from India increased its importance.
- Gradually generals began influencing decisions.
- Eventually the army justified coups in the name of stability.

Economic Structure at Independence

- The colonial economy focused on agriculture and raw material exports.
- Industrial development was limited and uneven.
- Infrastructure was weak and poverty widespread.
- Pakistan therefore began with serious economic disadvantages.

Land Revenue and Feudal System

- British policies strengthened large landlords to ensure revenue collection.
- These feudal elites controlled vast lands and local politics.
- Peasants remained poor and dependent.
- This unequal structure continued in Pakistan's politics.

Political Effects of Feudalism

- Landlords dominated elections and assemblies.
- Politics revolved around personal loyalty rather than ideology.
- Middle class participation remained limited.
- Democratic institutions could not develop strong roots.

Communal Politics under British Rule

- Separate electorates divided people on religious lines.
- The British used 'divide and rule' to maintain control.
- Communal mistrust increased over time.
- Partition and later political tensions were partly products of this policy.

Partition and Administrative Vacuum

- After 1947 many experienced officials stayed in India.
- Pakistan lacked trained staff and office infrastructure.
- Millions of refugees needed immediate assistance.
- State formation began under severe pressure and chaos.

Centralization of Power

- Colonial governance concentrated authority at the top.
- Pakistan continued this practice by strengthening the center over provinces.
- Local governments remained weak.
- This limited public participation and slowed development.

Government of India Act 1935 as Interim Constitution

- Pakistan temporarily adopted this colonial law.
- It gave strong powers to governors and the executive.
- Emergency provisions allowed dismissal of assemblies.
- This encouraged authoritarian rule instead of parliamentary democracy.

Weak Political Institutions

- During colonial rule, political training was limited.
- Few leaders had experience running governments.
- Political parties lacked organization and discipline.
- Therefore bureaucracy easily overshadowed politicians.

Executive Overreach

- Governors and Governor Generals dismissed prime ministers and assemblies.
- Such actions undermined parliamentary supremacy.
- Constitutional norms were violated repeatedly.
- This weakened faith in democracy.

Bureaucratic–Military Oligarchy

- Civil servants and military officers formed a powerful alliance.
- They controlled policy and decision making.
- Elected representatives were marginalized.
- This oligarchy shaped Pakistan's early state structure.

Challenges to Nation Building

- Pakistan contained diverse ethnic and linguistic groups.
- Each had its own culture and history.
- Without inclusive policies, unity was difficult to achieve.
- Colonial centralization failed to accommodate diversity.

Federalism and Provincial Autonomy Issues

- Colonial provinces had limited powers and depended on the center.
- Pakistan continued this centralized system.
- Provinces demanded control over finance and administration.
- Conflicts weakened national integration.

Positive Contributions of Colonial Legacy

- Some institutions provided stability and continuity.
- Civil service efficiency, legal system, and railways helped administration.
- These structures allowed the state to function.
- Thus colonial legacy was not entirely negative.

Negative Consequences

- However, authoritarian culture dominated governance.
- Power remained centralized and elitist.
- People had little participation in politics.
- Military and bureaucracy became too powerful.

Overall Impact on State Formation

- Pakistan developed strong coercive institutions but weak democratic ones.
- Political instability and coups followed.
- Federal tensions increased.
- State formation remained incomplete and contested.

Critical Evaluation

- The problem was not inheritance itself but failure to reform it.
- Pakistan needed to democratize colonial institutions.
- Instead many structures were continued unchanged.
- This produced imbalance between authority and representation.

Lessons for Contemporary Pakistan

- Strengthen parliament and political parties.
- Promote local government and provincial autonomy.
- Ensure civilian control over military.
- Encourage citizen participation for sustainable democracy.

Conclusion

- Colonial legacy deeply influenced Pakistan's political path.
- Strong bureaucracy and army shaped state formation.
- Democracy developed slowly due to centralized structures.
- Understanding this history helps students analyze current challenges clearly.

References

- Alavi (1972); Binder (1961); Jalal (1995);
- Rizvi (2000); Sayeed (1967); Talbot (2012)